and cooks.[22]

Akbar's 'fire-worship' was hardly the end of his provocations. Another day, Akbar entered his audience hall, 'his forehead marked like a Hindu . . . [with] jewelled strings tied on his wrists by Brahmans, by way of a blessing'. He was celebrating Rakhi; wearing these protective threads would become quite the fashion in Akbar's court.[23]

As the years went by, Akbar would try out many other sacred and protective rituals. 'The list of such reports is long,' writes Azfar Moin. By the time Akbar was done, he had worn the Parsi kusti as well as the Hindu rakhi; he had 'memorized one thousand and one names of the Sun in Sanskrit; he had . . . matched the color of his clothes to the planet of the day; he had practiced rites of "fire worship" in Brahmanical and Zoroastrian style; he had modified his diet according to tantric principles . . . '

The hands-on emperor was putting himself in the hands of his true Maker, whoever He might be; trusting Him to take Akbar's side against his mortal enemies.

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'Make your preparations, Father, for a long journey,' said Akbar to Monserrate before he began to march towards his impudent half-brother Muhammad Hakim, 'for you are going with me.'[24]

And it is good that he did: the Jesuit's awestruck eyes reveal, far more than Abul Fazl ever can for all he tries, the sheer majesty of the emperor of Hindustan at this time. Even if Akbar 'thought as much of [Hakim] as an eagle of a mosquito', as Monserrate claims, he marched with all the pomp at his disposal. It began modestly enough, with a small camp, including Akbar's two older boys, Salim and Murad, some of his wives and older daughters, even Akbar's mother, Hamida, for the first two days – the ladies and their maids riding camels, under white sunshades. Every night, Akbar's own white tent was pitched on a well-chosen spot, and around him, in strict hierarchy and following an unchanging map, the tents of his sons and nobility, and several urdu bazaars,[25] filled with 'all sorts of merchandise, so that these bazaars seem to belong to some wealthy city instead of to a camp'. A great flame atop a tall mast spread its light over the tents and beyond, guiding anyone who had fallen behind.